

meduza

How an exiled pirate media outlet breaks through the Kremlin's propaganda firewall

Alex
Aug 12, 2023

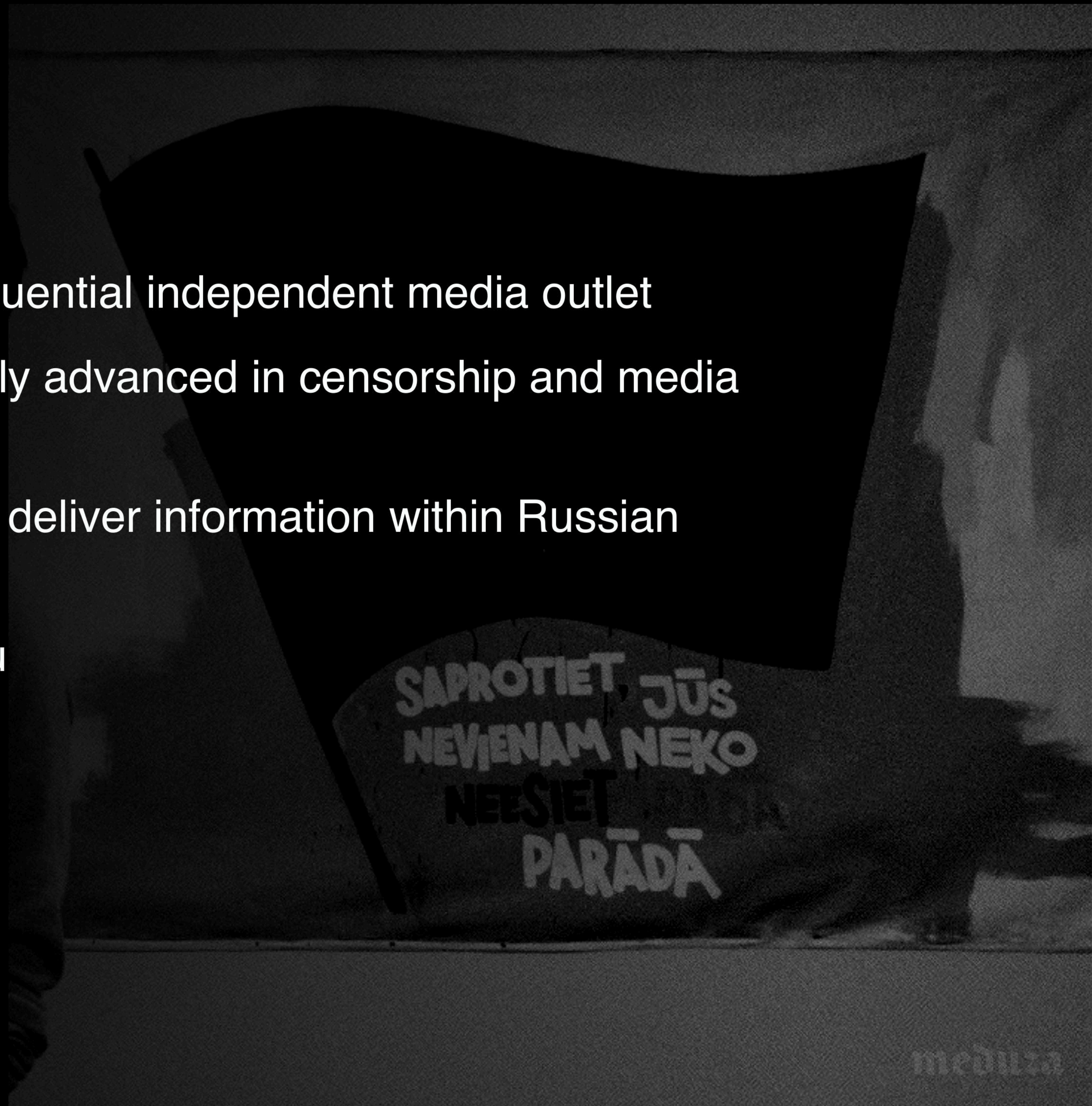
You'll learn

How Meduza has become the most influential independent media outlet

How Russia has become technologically advanced in censorship and media control

Why we are still alive, and how we can deliver information within Russian borders

Where it all goes and how it affects you



My name is Alex

Head of the Tech Department

Tech team:

- We design and develop our products in-house
- Today we are focusing on
 - how to deliver content to RU
 - how to protect our infrastructure





Russia

143.3 million



Russia

Belarus

Kazakhstan

Uzbekistan

Kyrgyzstan

Turkmenistan

Tajikistan

143.3 million + 95.4 million



Russia

Belarus

Kazakhstan

Uzbekistan

Kyrgyzstan

Azerbaijan

Turkmenistan

Tajikistan

Syria

Iran

China

North Korea

What might go wrong?

How it started...

2014

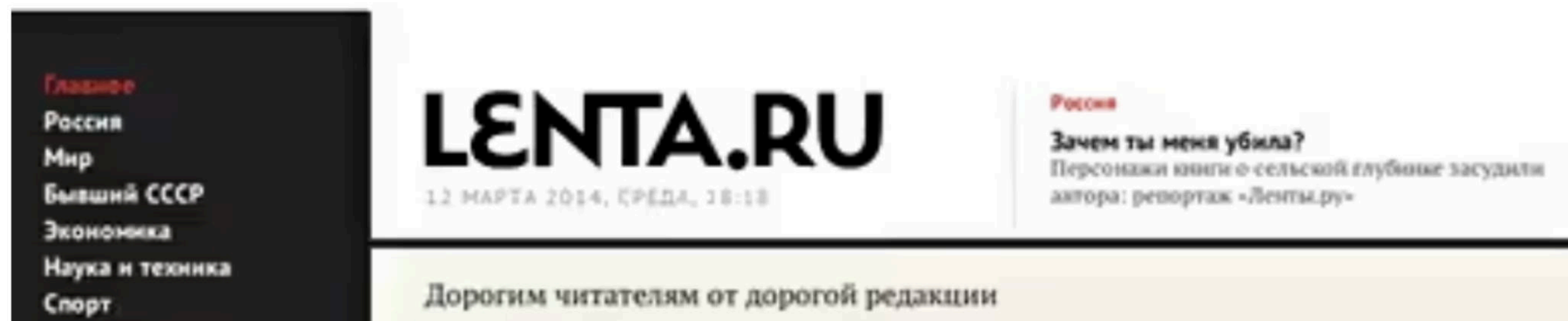


**IN A
GALAXY
FAR, FAR
AWAY**

Euromaidan



Editor of independent Russian news site replaced with pro-Kremlin figure



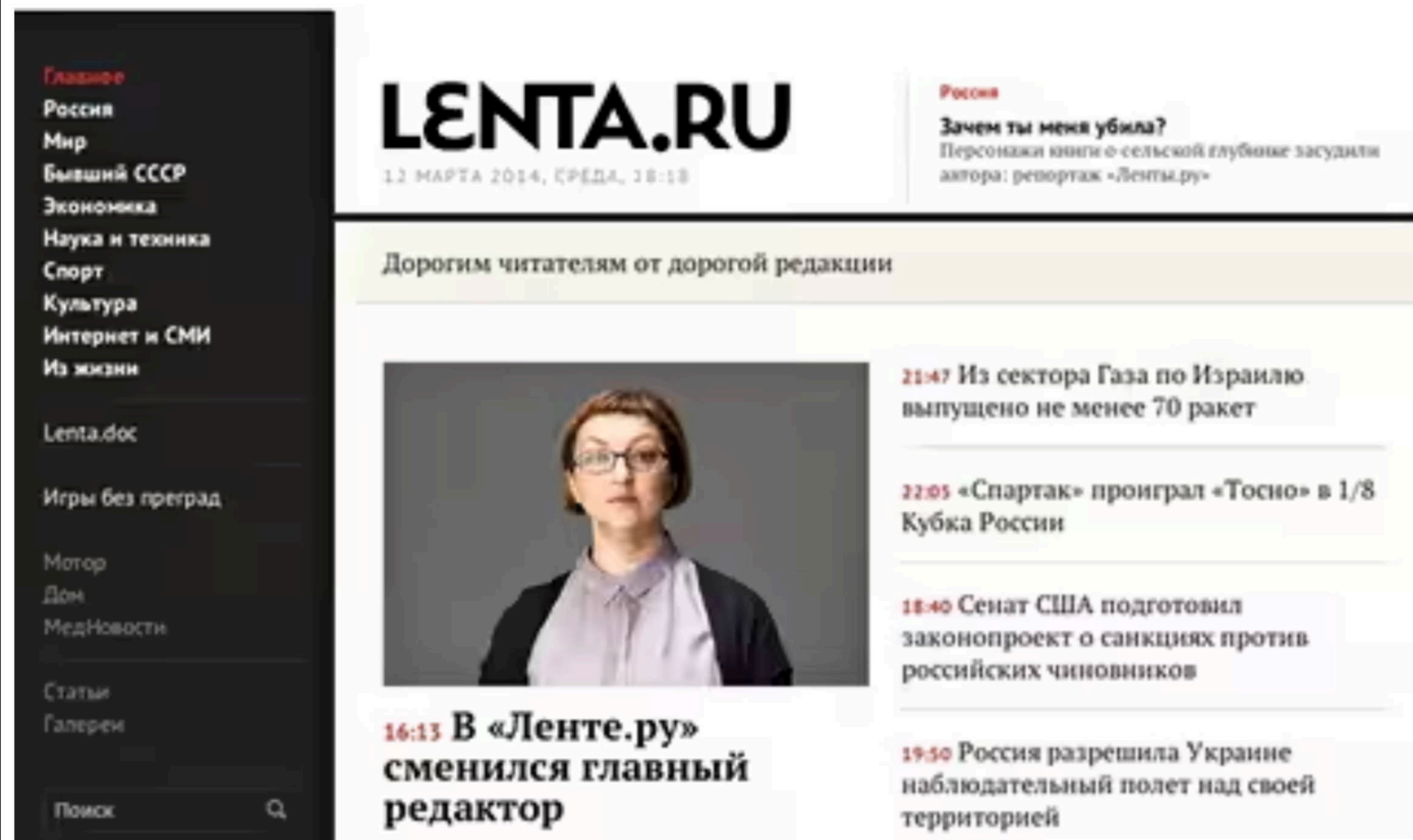
Russia's illegal annexation of Crimea and Sevastopol: Council renews sanctions for a further year

The Council today decided to renew **sanctions** introduced in **response to the illegal annexation of Crimea and Sevastopol by the Russian Federation** for a further year until **23 June 2022**.

**Russian government
decides to take
control of media and
Internet**

This is how Meduza appeared

Editor of independent Russian news site replaced with pro-Kremlin figure



Meduza in 2014: a small pirate ship

In a safe haven (EU)

Decentralized leadership & funding

Technologically advanced

Security focused

Appealing to younger generation

And it is never boring with us!



Negative thinking is our strength

meduza

meduza

НОВОСТИ

ТЕМЫ

КАРТОТЕКА

СТАТЬИ

ШАПИТО



MEDUZA — через день

Платформа Русь
*Журналист Сергей
Смирнов — об истории
«Русской планеты»*

БАНК РОССИИ — через день

Курс евро ЦБ РФ вырос на три рубля

ПРЕЗИДЕНТ РОССИИ — через день

Путин подписал закон о сборах с
торговли

ИНТЕРФАКС — через день

Более 50 человек пропали без вести
после крушения траулера у берегов
Чукотки

meduza

Meduza today

Meduza is the biggest media outlet and the most influential, which is (still) reaching millions of Russians within the country

Website — 12 million unique users

Mobile app — more than 1.5 million downloads

Telegram — more than 1.5 million subscribers

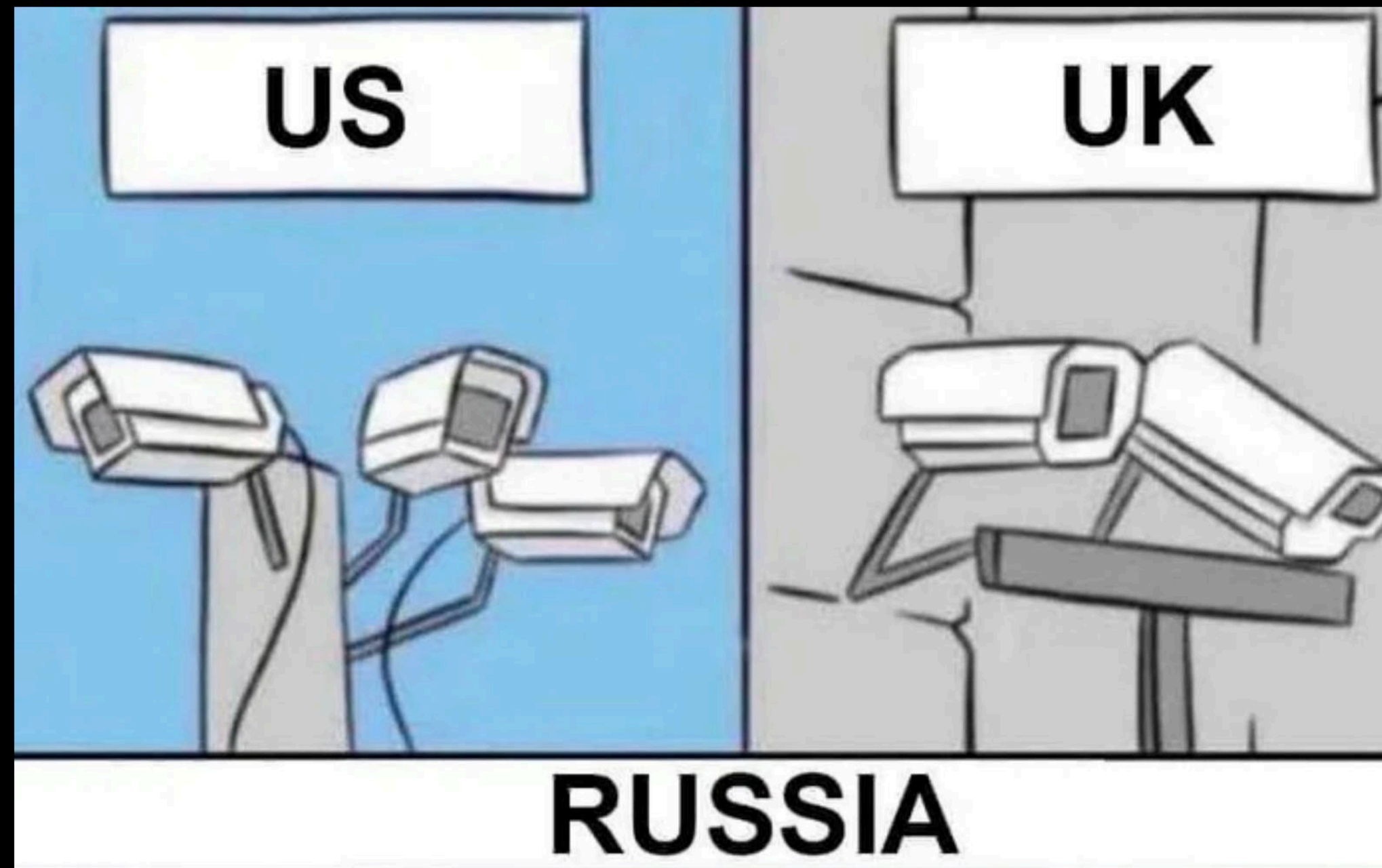
YouTube channel — 14 million views

Podcast studio, newsletters, etc.

Outlawed in Russia since 2023, blocked on 2022

**In the meantime
Russia has advanced
technologically**

2014



2022 — DPI implemented everywhere

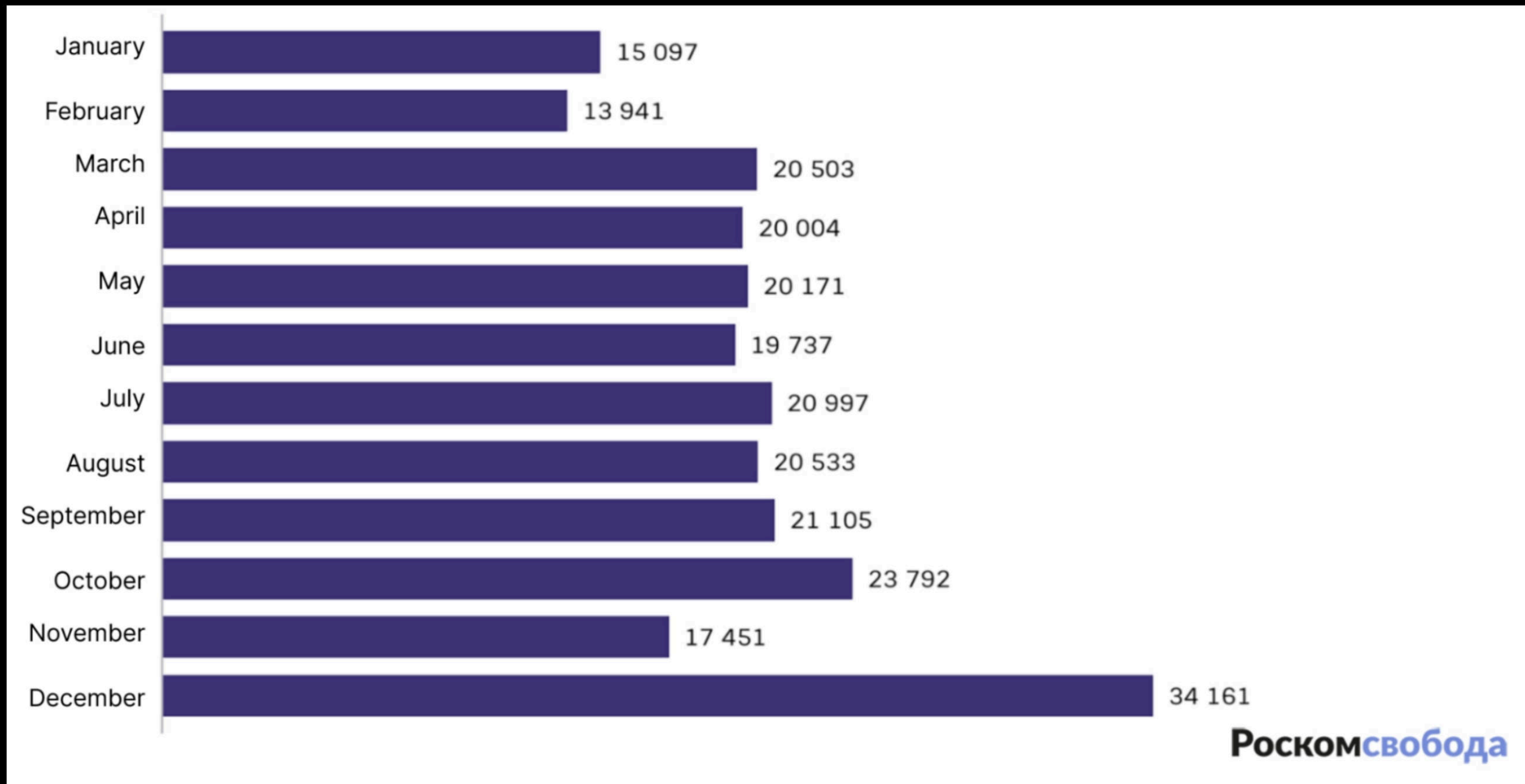
Number of blockings comparison 21 vs 22



2021 3 586

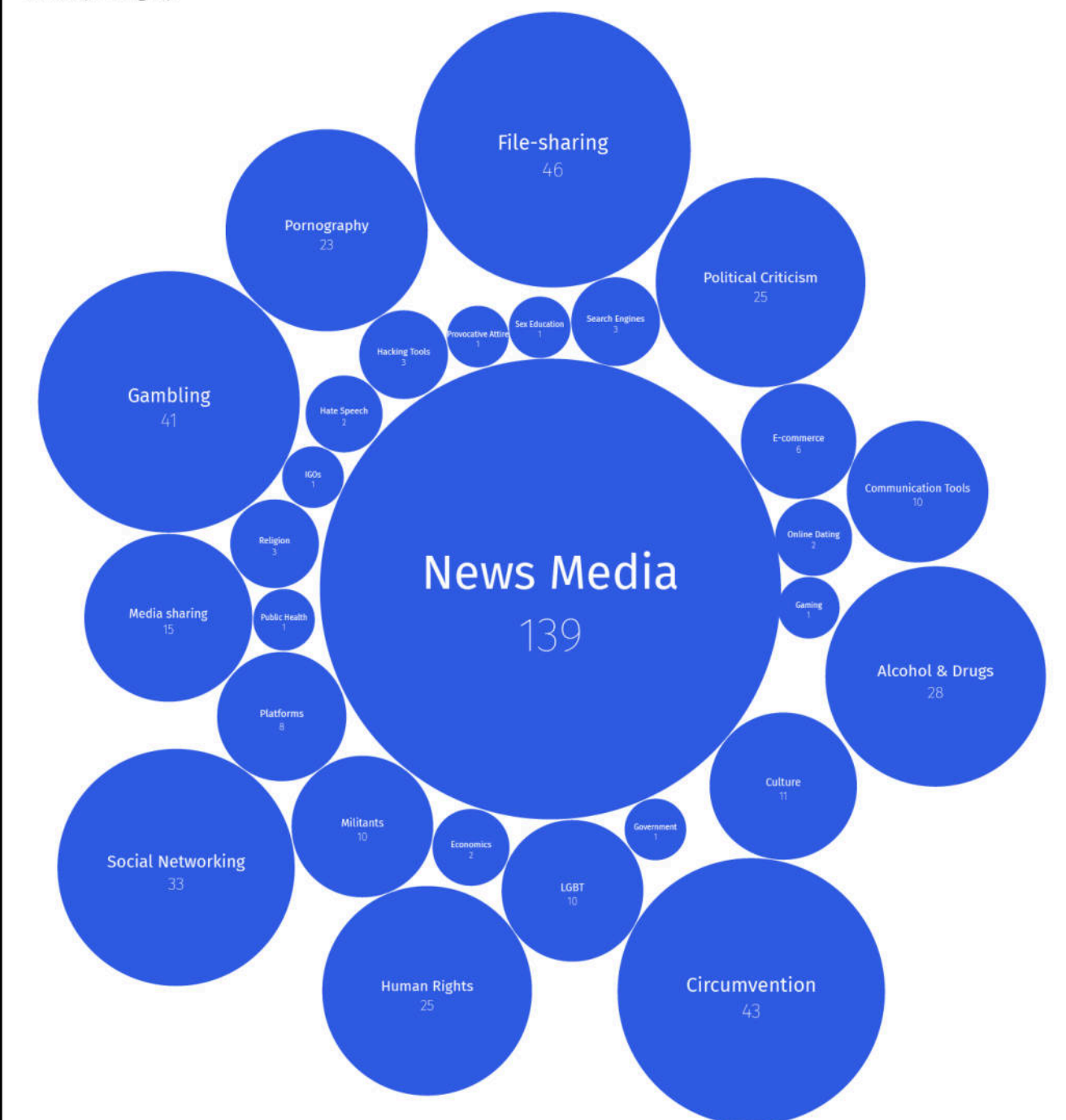
2022 110 684

Massive blockings



Categories of restricted content in Russia

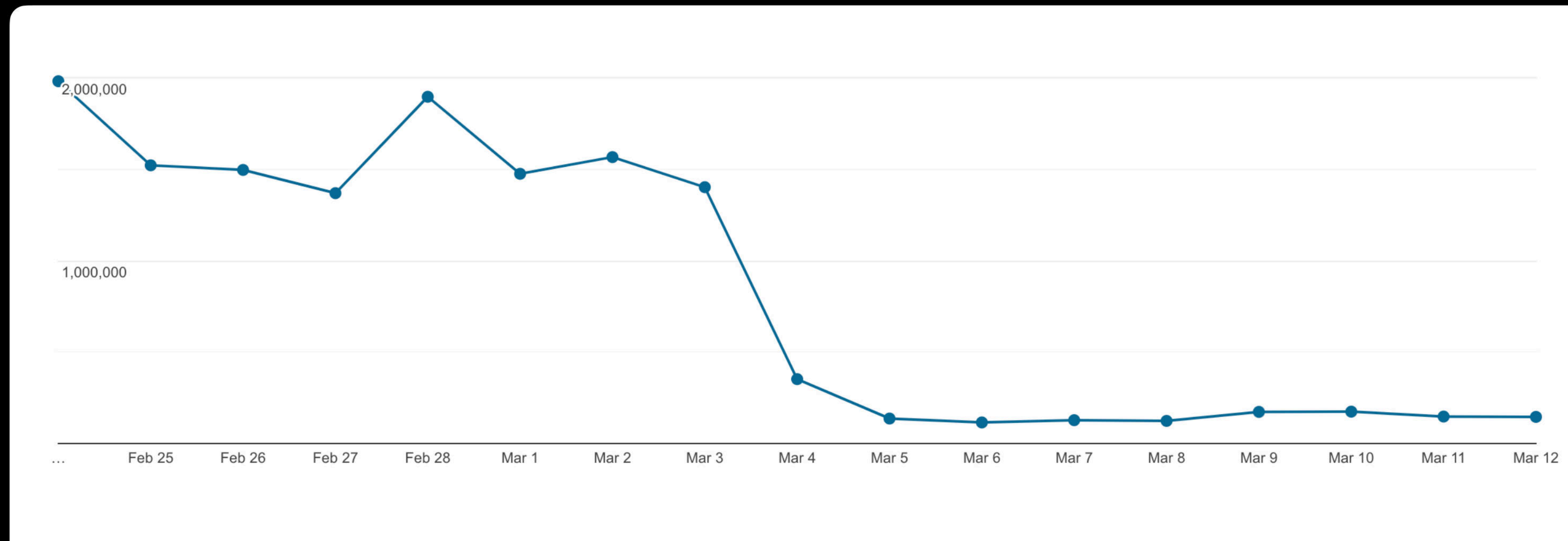
Domains found to be blocked in Russia from January 2022 to February 2023 by category.



Source: OONI measurements from 1st Jan 2022 to 15th Feb 2023

What our miserable life after being blocked looks like

Audience immediately drops by 90%



**You blocked
everything**
**What is your next
step?**

Circumvention

TOR blocked

Major VPN services blocked

Promotion of VPN services is not allowed

Discreditation of VPN services

Wireguard, OpenVPN protocols blocked

Control of media space

Control of search and recommendation services

Launch of fake independent accounts

Use of social networks to spread propaganda

Kill virality (you can't repost)

Use of fear

What about global companies?

Facebook, Instagram, Twitter blocked

High risk of YouTube block

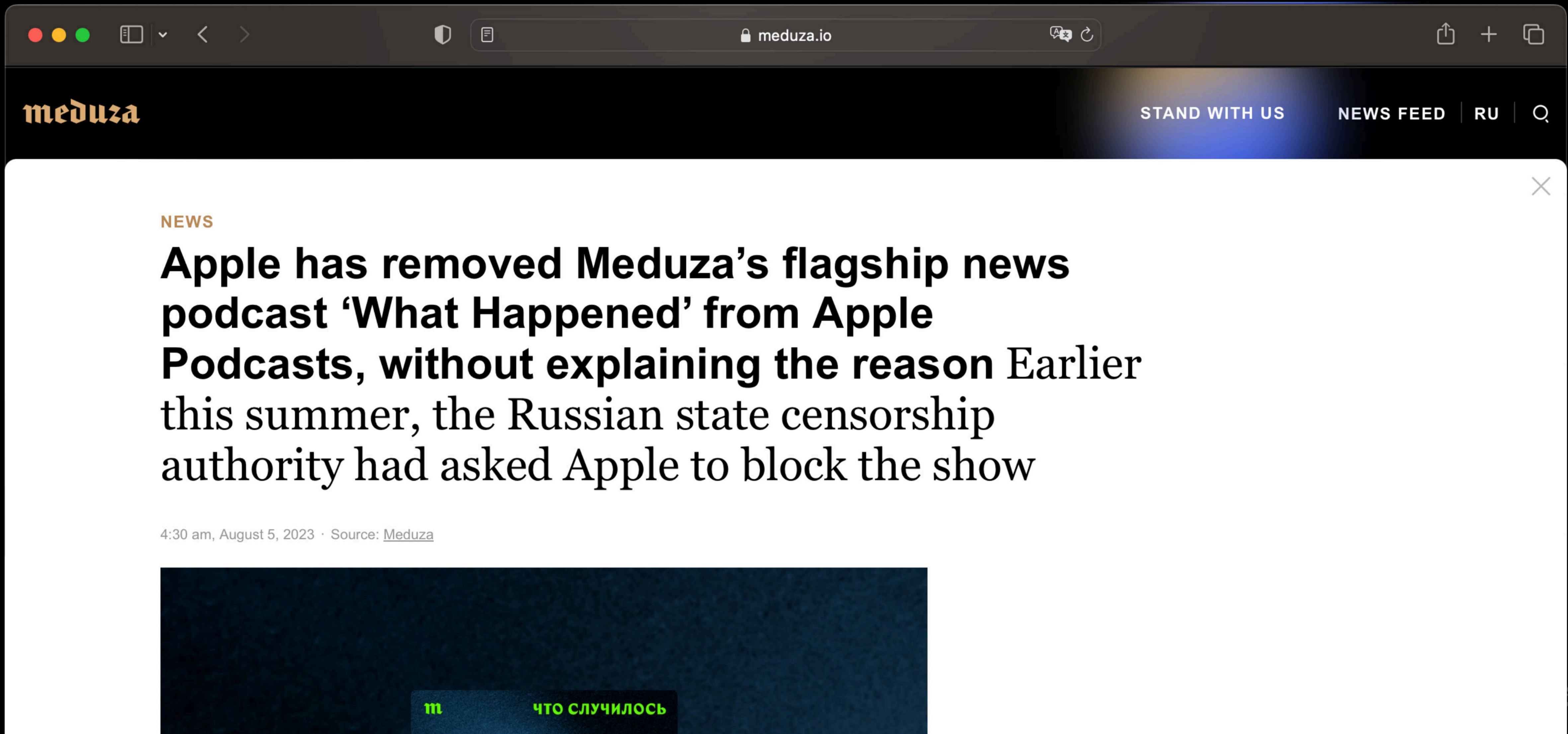
Pressure on Google and Apple

Google news blocked, **Google search has been blocked today!!**

People pushed to move to national platforms

But sometimes they help RU government

Apple



meduza

STAND WITH US

NEWS FEED

RU



NEWS

Apple has removed Meduza's flagship news podcast 'What Happened' from Apple Podcasts, without explaining the reason

Earlier this summer, the Russian state censorship authority had asked Apple to block the show

4:30 am, August 5, 2023 · Source: [Meduza](#)

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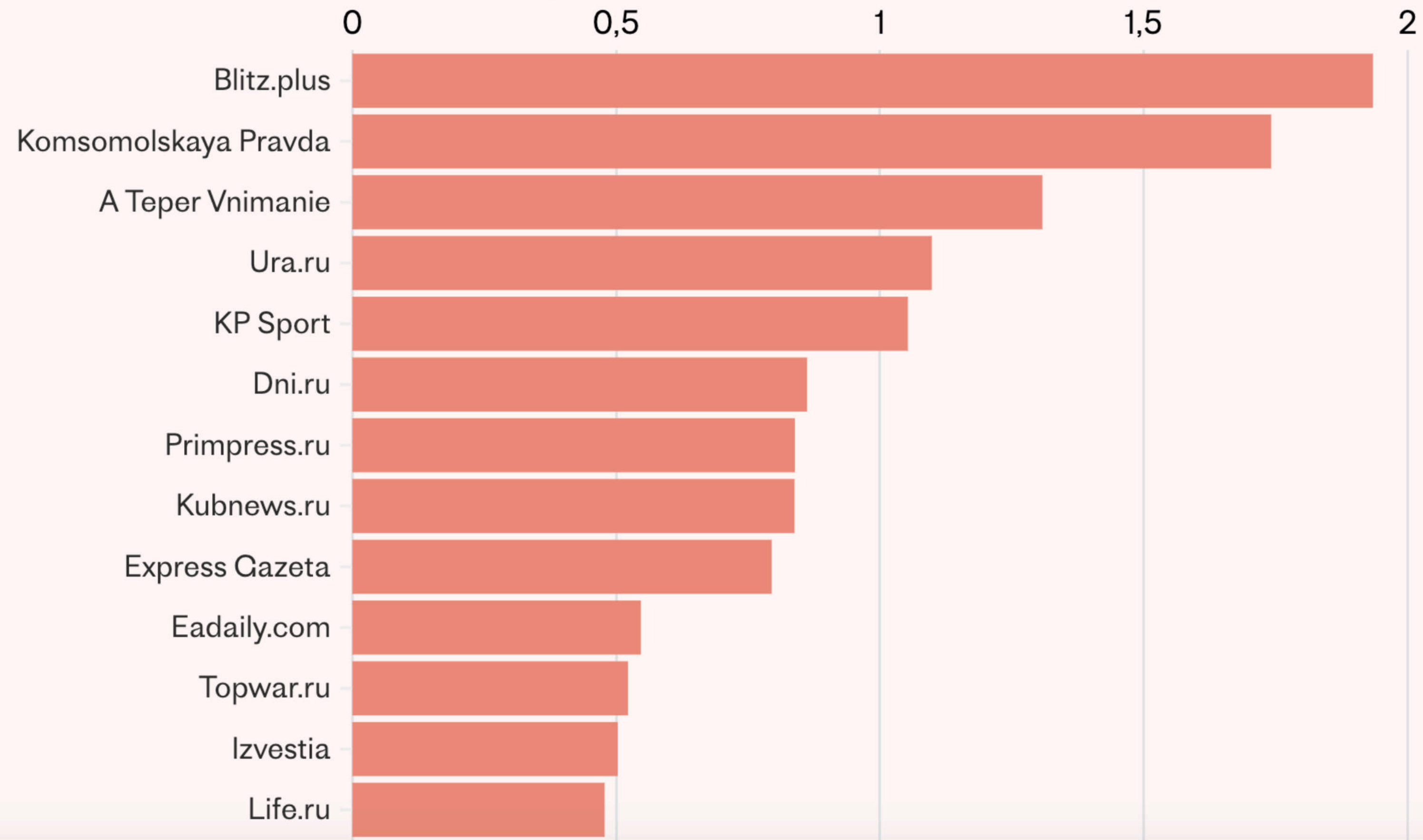
ЧТО СЛУЧИЛОСЬ

Google Search

i IMPORTANT
STORIES

Top 30 popular Russian media outlets in Google Discover

Average daily number of user clicks from Google Discover recommendations to Russian media sites in February 2023, in millions



**But how did we
survive?**

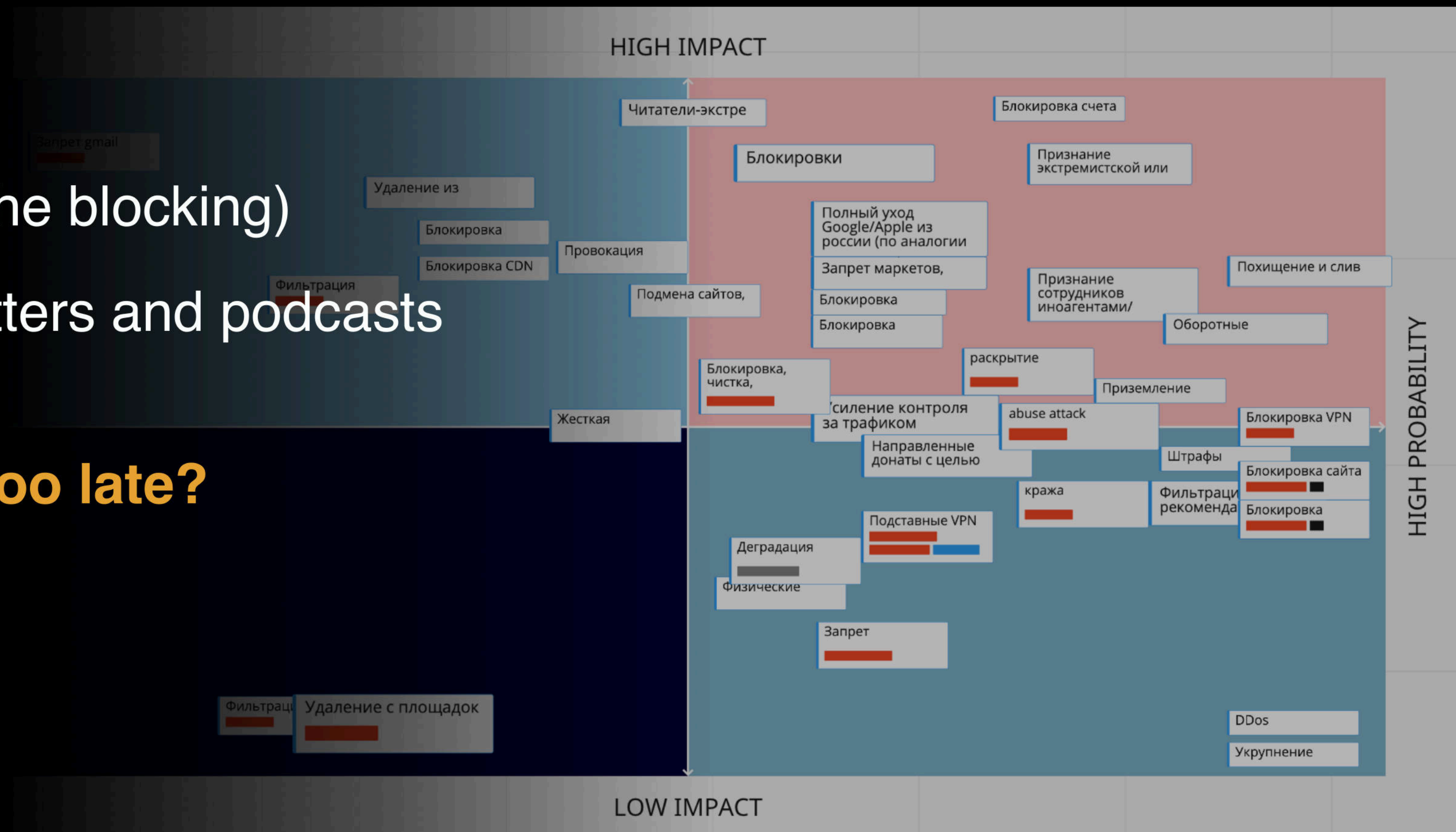
Negative thoughts keep us prepared

Disaster plan

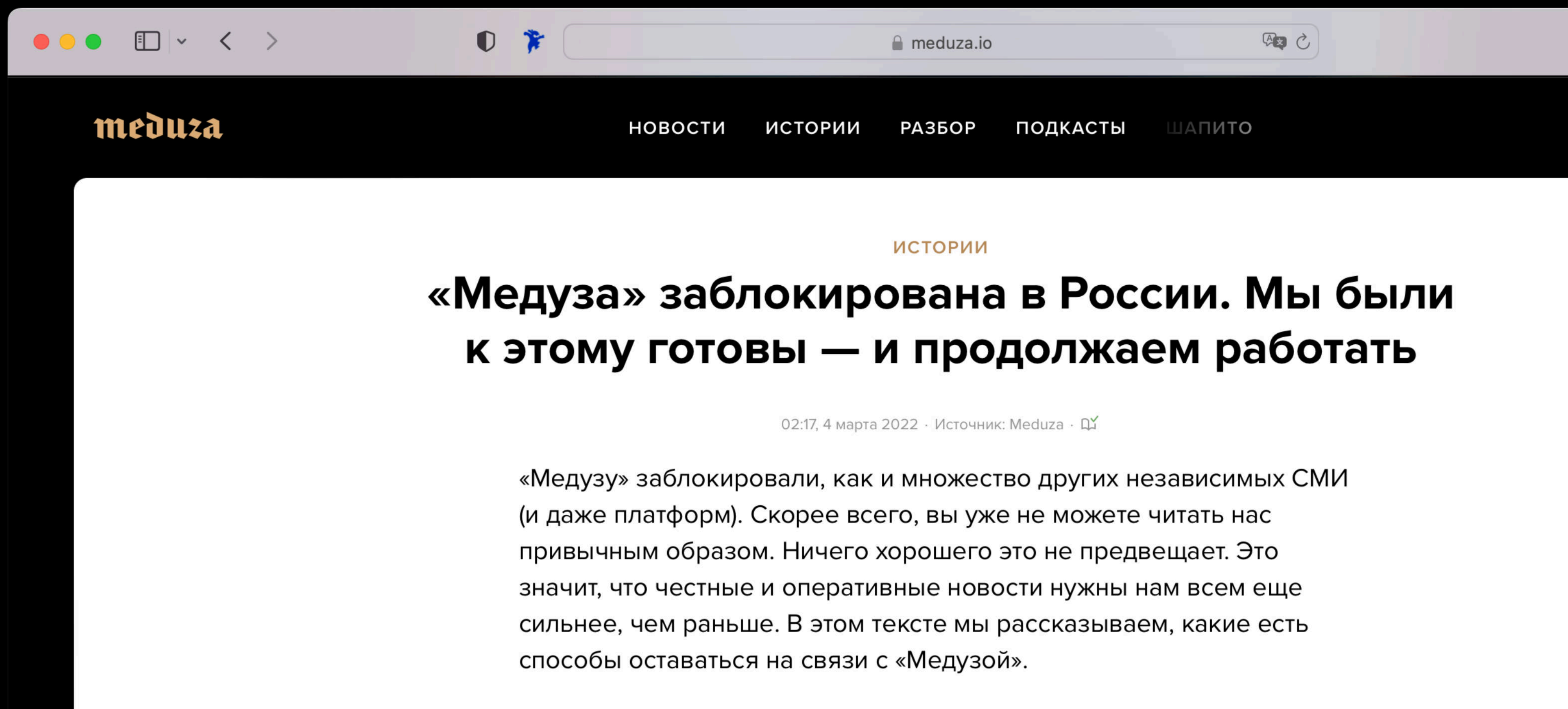
SOS communication (before the blocking)

Diversity of platforms (newsletters and podcasts are awesome btw)

What can we do before it's too late?



People are still there. They just need another way



Telegram

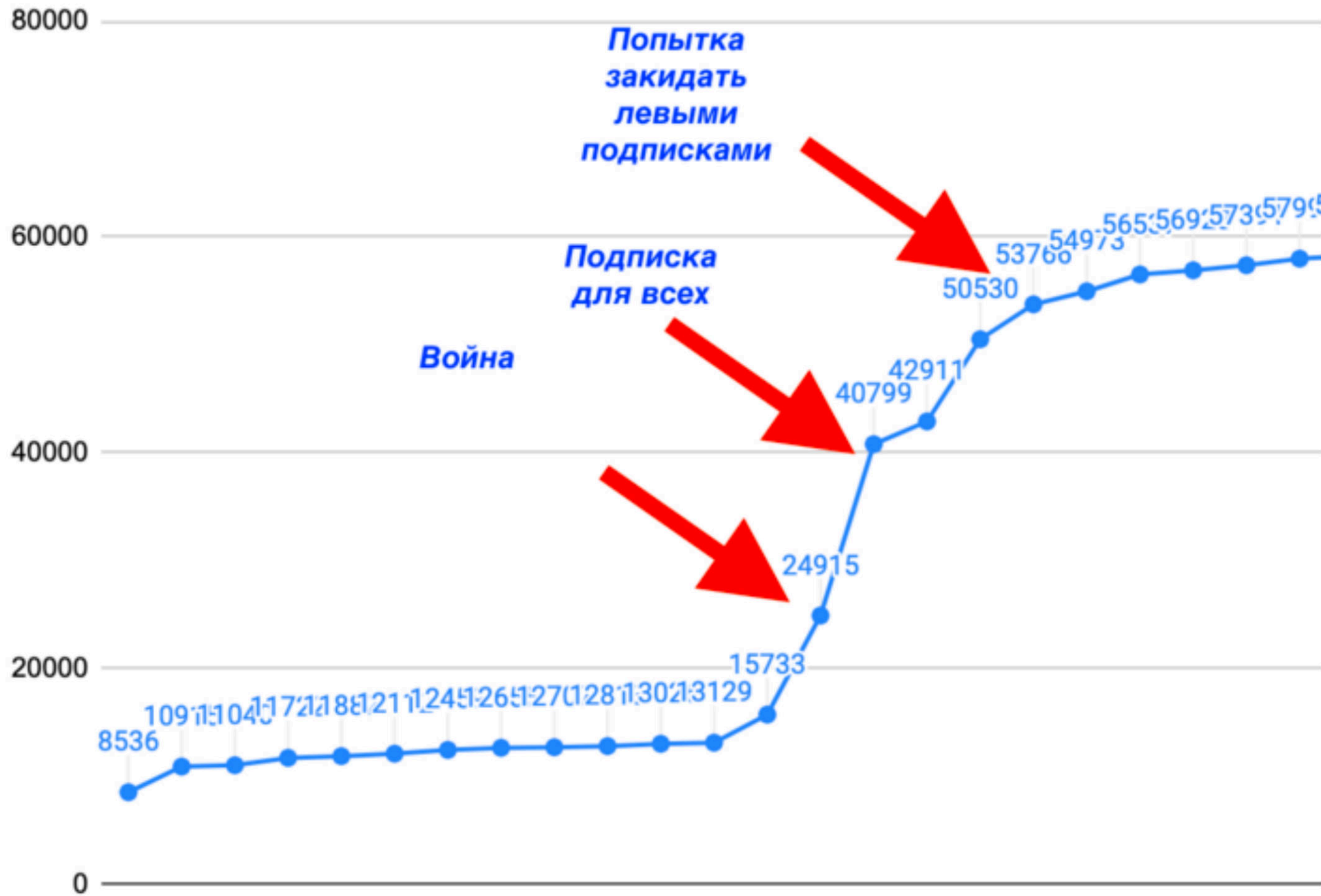


Mobile App



Newsletter

Подписчики



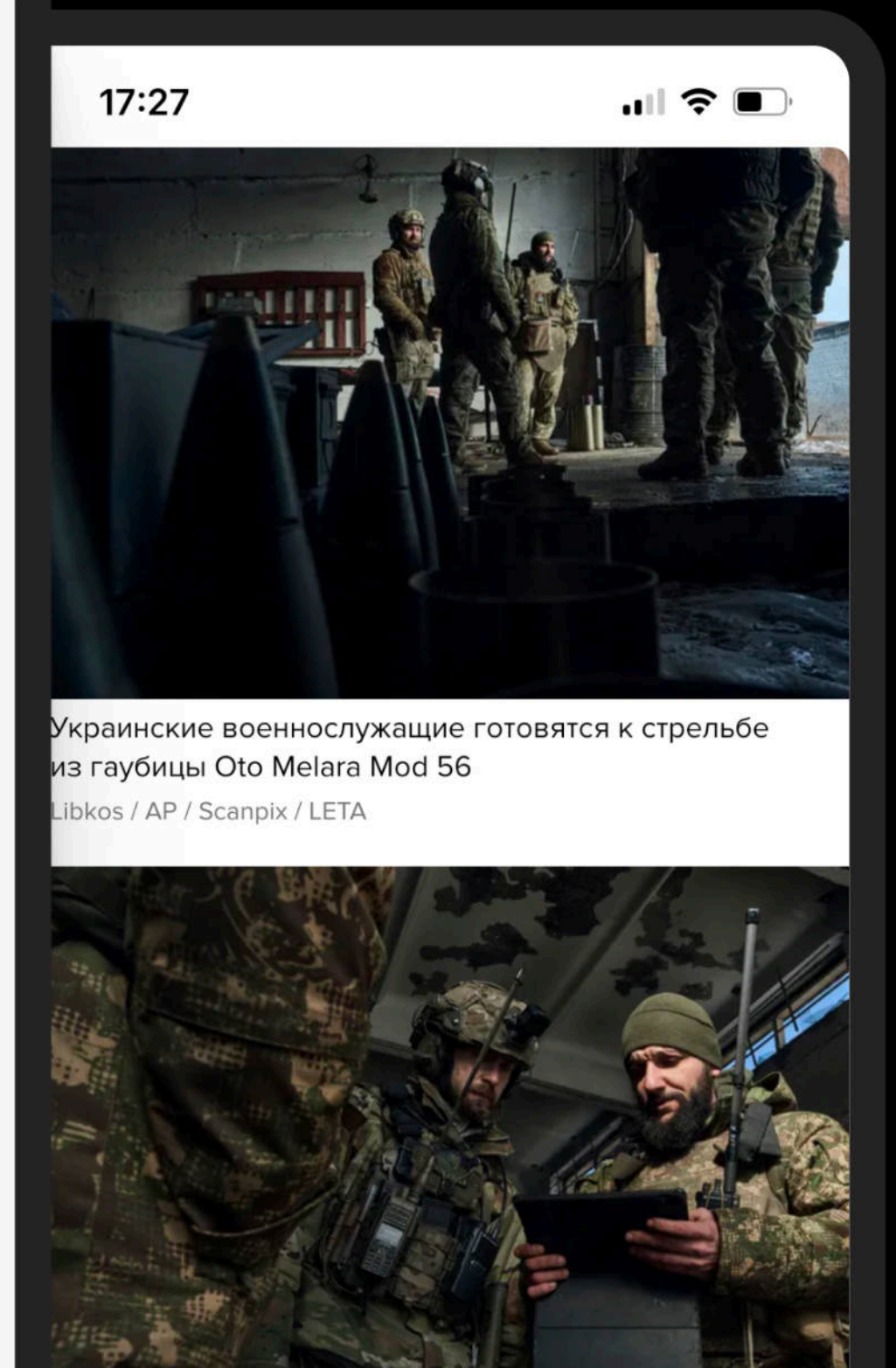
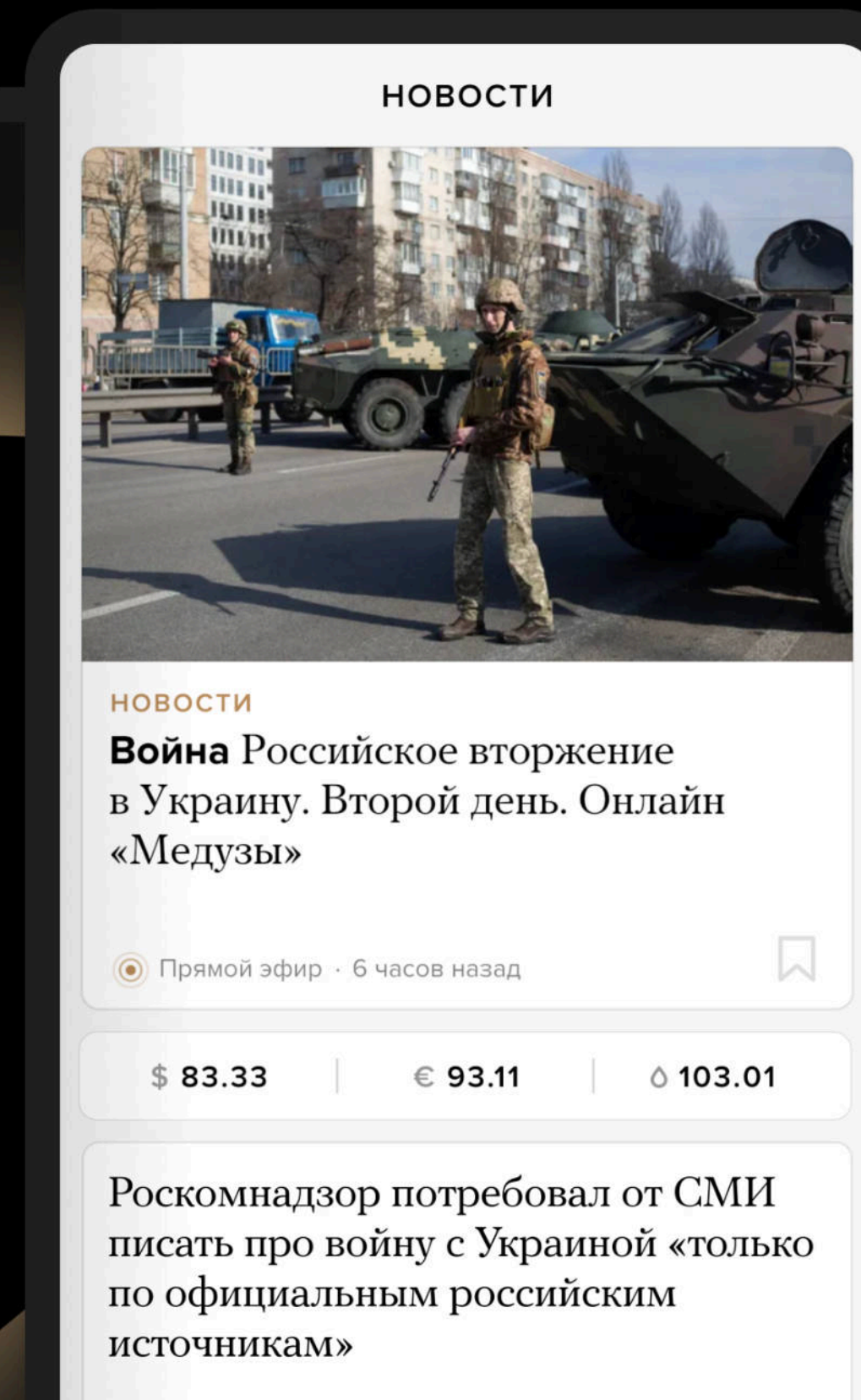
Mobile app

While it is in store, you can do whatever you want

Embedded circumvention tools

P2P and obfuscation - why doesn't that work?

Automated mirror delivery



Mobile app - preparing to worst

Pre-caching of content

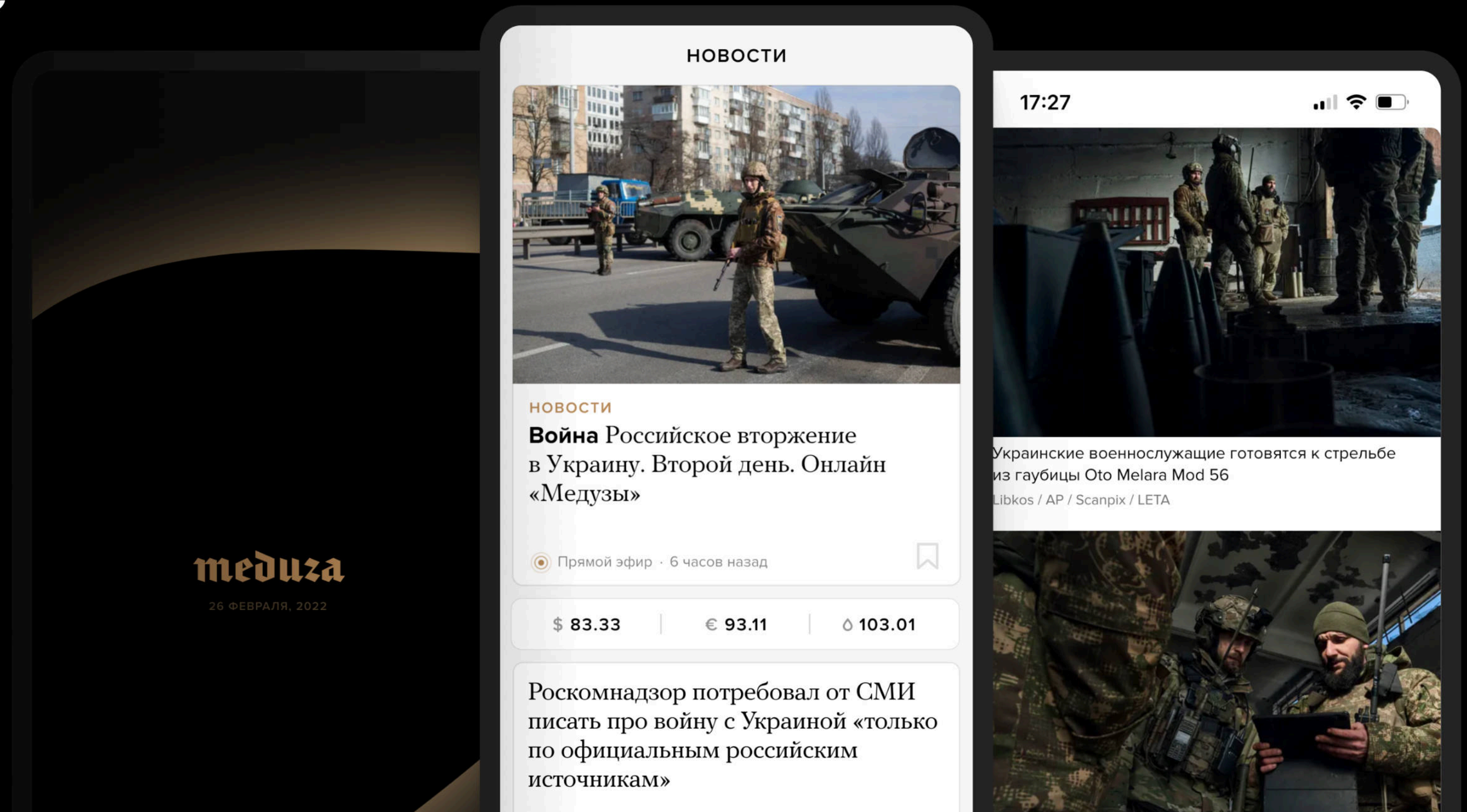
Lite version - p2p in the future?

Emergency mode - cloud storage

Version w/o Firebase

Mac Version

Etc.



Automated mirror rotation

Monitoring of blockings (**3 times a day now**)

Segmentation

Automated mirror issuing

Mirrors Rotation APP 03:30

0 1 2 3

Количество пользователей с ошибками для домена qy72uiv77w.onijestm6r.click:

7 8 9

Количество пользователей с ошибками для домена x6uenblhs9.dv75hb34fb.art: 149

0 1 2 3

Управляемое зеркало qy72uiv77w.onijestm6r.click работает, действия не требуются

7 8 9

Управляемое зеркало x6uenblhs9.dv75hb34fb.art работает, действия не требуются

4 5 6

Количество пользователей с ошибками для домена mw0mb6cme5.ftwx0ykc4d.best:

4 5 6

Управляемое зеркало mw0mb6cme5.ftwx0ykc4d.best работает, действия не требуются

Magic-links =)

Domain fronted links

Can be easily shared via messenger

избить Кашина. Впоследствии псковский губернатор заявил, что никогда не был в

эт

ут

бе

С

А.

об

О.

пр

В

не

2010 году.

И последний раз про Magic link!

Это магическая ссылка: она открывает лайт-версию материала. Ее можно отправить тому, у кого «Медуза» заблокирована — и все откроется!

Будьте осторожны: «Медуза» в РФ — «нежелательная» организация.

Не посылайте наши статьи людям, которым вы не доверяете.

Ок!



PDFs are also great (we're surprised too)

Simple, but they work perfectly

Step away from the screen: tell your parents about the war

губернатор заявил, что никогда не был в этом заведении, однако жена Веселова утверждает, что у нее есть аудиозапись беседы Горбунова и Турчака.

Совладелец компании «Заслон» Александр Горбунов, которого обвиняемые в покушении на журналиста Олега Кашина называли организатором преступления, дал РБК первое интервью. В беседе с изданием Горбунов заявил, что не причастен к нападению на Кашина в 2010 году.



Never stop looking for new paths

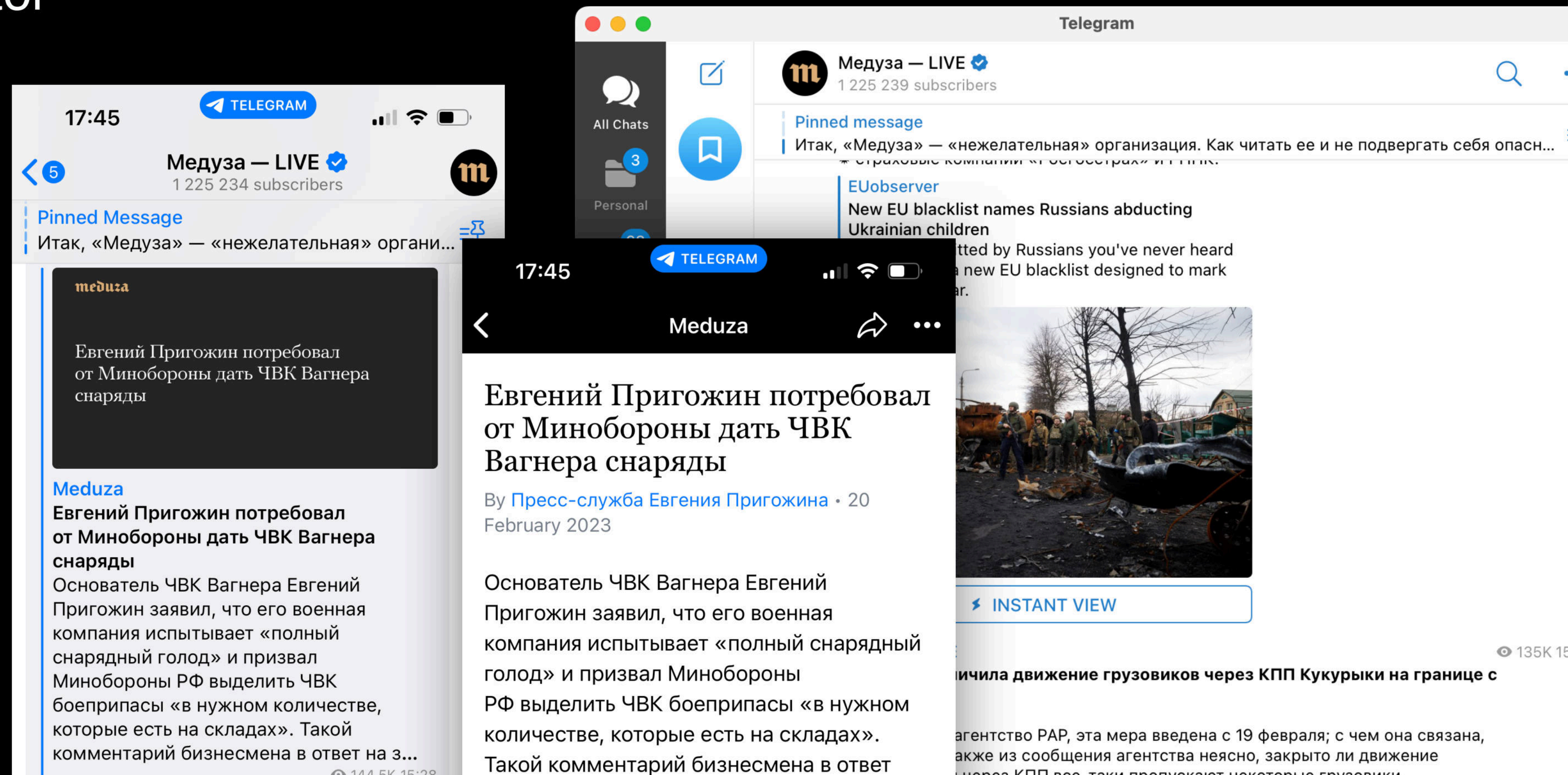
Instagram story generator

Instant View, AMP

Light Meduza

News aggregators

News broadcast



So, what's the score?

We don't have resources, but we're inventive and creative

We trying to be always step ahead

We have a good will, so people help us

We believe that Independent journalism and freedom of information is not a gift — it is an achievement that has to be protected.

And we need your help!

We're looking for help with

Bright ideas from clever people

Any kind of support — resources, knowledge, funding

New technologies and expertise

Circumvention tools

We're open to any collaborations

Read us and spread the word about us <http://meduza.io/en>

Contact me
alex@meduza.io

Support us



Thank you!

The future of the Internet in Russia — what's next?

Global services totally replaced by Russian services or those controlled by the state (incl. Google and Apple)

Circumvention tools available only for advanced tech users

More advanced blocking, i.e. automated discovery and blocking of content, including audio-visual content.

Criminalization of reading forbidden materials

Faster discovery and blocking of undesirable content

Sovereign Internet and separation of Russians from outer world



We expect isolation within 1 year



Russia

Belarus

Kazakhstan

Uzbekistan

Kyrgyzstan

Azerbaijan

Turkmenistan

Tajikistan

Syria

Iran

China

North Korea

I HAVE
SPOKEN

A silhouette of a person wearing a cape and holding a megaphone, positioned inside the letter 'O' of the word 'SPOKEN'. The entire graphic is white on a black background.

Contact me
alex@meduza.io

Support us



Thank you!